

THINK COLLEGE STORIES

CREDENTIAL PATHWAYS

Emerald's Story: Education as a Life-Long Value

This series of stories aims to shed light on the transformative power of higher education credentials for students with intellectual disability. Through real-life examples, we explore how earning credentials in various fields has not only equipped these individuals with essential skills but has also paved the way for meaningful employment opportunities.

4-year university

Education/ASL

Colorado

Emerald learned about the importance of education from a young age. She said, "I spent a lot of years when I was a kid in a Chinese orphanage, and I did not get to go to school. Now that I have a chance I want to learn a lot." Emerald chose to attend University of Colorado, Colorado Springs (UCCS) where she had the opportunity to explore her career interests in teaching and supporting Deaf students.

The Office of Inclusive Services (OIS) at UCCS offers a 4-year, inclusive program for transition-age adults with intellectual disability. The program is accredited by the Inclusive Higher Education Accreditation Council (IHEAC). Students earn a Comprehensive Higher Education Certificate with a specific area of focus. To earn this certificate, students must complete 75 credits/clock hours, maintain a cumulative GPA of 2.0 or higher, take at least half of their courses in their area of focus, successfully complete four semesters of work experience, and participate regularly in campus activities with other UCCS students.

Emerald earned her Comprehensive Higher Education Certificate in 2024. She successfully completed five American Sign Language (ASL) courses and gained the skills to use ASL proficiently. Additionally, Emerald took Deaf Culture and Special Topics in ASL Deafhood, two courses that gave her insight into the experiences of the Deaf community. Emerald took Human Services courses as well to gain skills for working in helping professions and communicating effectively. She said, "my classes impacted my life by opening up opportunities for my career and made me feel more confident in communicating with Deaf people and helping them to be successful, which made me feel good about myself."

The classes Emerald took at UCCS, while receiving services from the OIS, allowed her to learn ASL, which is essential for a career in supporting Deaf students. Her certificate also allowed her to learn all the soft skills needed to be successful in a teaching job. She learned to keep a calendar, write and respond to texts and emails, be on time, complete her work, communicate with co-workers, and be a great team player. Her credential led to a job after college as a Teacher's Assistant at the Colorado School for the Deaf & Blind doing the work she loves in her area of study.

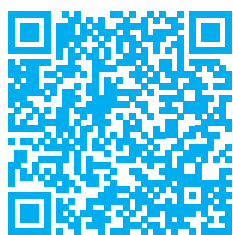


"My classes impacted my life by opening up opportunities for my career and made me feel more confident in communicating with Deaf people and helping them to be successful, which made me feel good about myself."



Why are postsecondary education credentials important?

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Emily's Story: A Quest for Independence

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4-year university

Dog Training/Hospitality

North Carolina

Emily always had a vision to live life to the fullest. She was determined to live on her own and have a career working with animals. To make that future happen, Emily explored several different inclusive postsecondary education programs, finally deciding to attend the University Participant (UP) Program at Western Carolina University (WCU).

The WCU UP Program provides an inclusive, 2-year, on-campus living and learning experience for college-age students with intellectual disability. The program is accredited by the Inclusive Higher Education Accreditation Council (IHEAC). The goal of the program is to facilitate students' transition from secondary school to adult life with education, employment, and independent living. Students enrolled through UP live on campus, take 3-4 inclusive classes with their peers, work at least 10 hours per week, and get involved with campus activities that are open to all students.

While in college, Emily quickly realized she specifically wanted a career training dogs to work in law enforcement. Although WCU is in a small community with limited animal jobs nearby, Emily was dedicated to gaining as many skills as possible. She found jobs to help her hospitality and customer service skills and then she moved into learning more about law enforcement and working with police dogs through her job with WCU Parking Services.

Alongside these jobs, Emily took several classes with to help her gain more skills to prepare for her future. Emily chose her classes by looking at her future goals and by looking at what the university had to offer to give her the most well-rounded education possible. After her two years, Emily had taken a total of 44 credit hours of college classes.

After her two years at WCU, Emily graduated in 2024 with her Certificate of Accomplishment. Then, she was ready to take her dreams to the next level, enrolling in an official dog training school for a 6-month, full-time training program to get direct experience working with and training dogs to become a certified dog trainer.

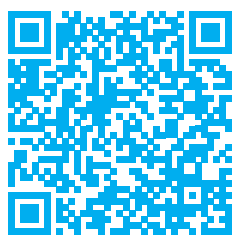
Once she completes dog training school, Emily will be able to move into her own apartment. Thanks to the classes, skills, and work experiences she gained at WCU, she has built the confidence to live the independent life she has always dreamed of.



Emily graduated in 2024 with her Certificate of Accomplishment and then went on to dog training school, thanks to the classes, skills, and work experiences she gained at WCU.

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CREDENTIAL PATHWAYS

Janai's Story: An Opportunity to Achieve her Dreams

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4-year university

Early childhood education

Virginia

Janai's dream was to work as an assistant teacher with young children. To make her dream a reality, Janai attended Virginia Commonwealth University's (VCU) ACE-IT in College program.

VCU's ACE-IT in College is an inclusive certificate program for transition-age adults with intellectual disability. The program is accredited by the Inclusive Higher Education Accreditation Council (IHEAC). Students earn a Certificate of Completion from the VCU School of Education after fulfilling the requirements of their Academic and Career Plan. The Academic and Career Plan includes 20+ VCU course credits, campus employment, and an internship. Students audit 2-3 VCU classes per semester with individualized support provided for participation in employment, college classes, and campus activities.

While in college, Janai worked as a classroom assistant at VCU's Child Development Center and a communication assistant at VCU's Office of Continuing and Professional Education. She wrapped up her final semester in college as a teacher's assistant at the Virginia Museum of Fine Arts Early Childhood Education program.

Janai certainly wasn't alone in her college journey as she prepared for her career. Janai and the ACE-IT in College program staff worked collaboratively with a variety of partners, including Virginia's vocational rehabilitation agency, the Department for Aging and Rehabilitative Services (DARS); job coaches; campus employers; an internship business site; and an organization that provided supported employment services post-graduation.

Janai graduated from college with a Certificate of Completion, a strong resume, and skills to help her in her career search. Because of the relationships built between program staff, DARS, and a local organization that provides supported employment services, Janai could smoothly transition from college into the career search process and eventually on to her dream job as a teacher's assistant in a local preschool.

Janai always had a heart for teaching and wanted to impact children's lives. Her determination and skills ultimately led her to take advantage of every opportunity she got to excel. VCU's ACE-IT in College certificate program paved the way for opportunities, support, and guidance that Janai used to reach her career goals.

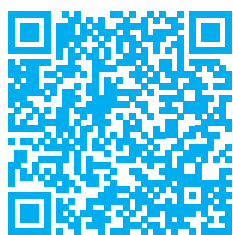


**Janai always had a heart for teaching and
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THINK COLLEGE STORIES

CREDENTIAL PATHWAYS

John's Story: All the Bases Covered

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4-year university

Professional sports

Illinois

John Wrenn has always been a self-starter. He joined the University of Illinois Chicago's (UIC) Cooperative Career Experience Program, or Co-Op, seeking an active job related to nursing, sports, or advocacy—not a job that involved sitting at a desk.

The Co-Op program is a 2-year, 36-credit hour pre-baccalaureate certificate program based in UIC's Department of Disability and Human Development. Students take 12 credits of core disability studies courses, 12 credits of work-based learning and internship experiences, and 12 credits of any 100 level elective courses from around the university that are aligned with their person-centered planning goals.

John entered the Co-Op program in Fall 2022, eager to gain more knowledge and experience. After several work experiences that helped him discover more about what he likes and doesn't like, he was hired as a member of the cleaning crew at Wrigley Field, home of the Chicago Cubs.

In July of his first season John earned Associate of the Month. His supervisors noted that he shows “a remarkable blend of adaptability, learning, and positive energy. His enthusiastic contributions have notably improved team dynamics and overall efficiency.” The 2023 season built John's confidence to continue to pursue a career in professional sports as an equipment manager.

During the offseason, John continued to impress Co-Op staff by applying his learning beyond class sessions and proactively identifying opportunities to support himself on his career path. John conducted informational interviews and took relevant courses—like Turf Management—through Coursera. He independently advocated for a promotion and earned one for the 2024 season: in the 1914 Club, Wrigley Field's luxury home plate club experience that has been dubbed “the coolest seats in baseball” since it was established in 2018.

John continues to independently pursue informational interviews and other opportunities that can support him in growing a career in professional sports. He is currently working on developing a plan to work for two teams whose seasons have minimal overlap. John's Co-Op classmates noticed his growing knowledge of work in professional sports. They have begun turning to John for advice regularly and asking him to be a member of their person-centered planning teams. The Co-Op team is so proud of John and excited to see everything in store for him!

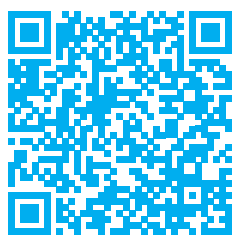


John knew he was interested in a job related to sports or advocacy, a job that wasn't a desk job, and he was successful in getting what he wanted working at Wrigley Field.



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Josh's Story: Thriving in the Hospitality Industry

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Josh attended the EAGLES Program at Auburn University ready to learn! At the EAGLES Program, Josh quickly identified his interest in hospitality and was able to incorporate earning micro-credentials into his college experience.

The EAGLES Program is a certificate program that provides the opportunity for students to engage in a 2 or 4-year campus residential experience. The goal of the EAGLES Program is to prepare students with intellectual disability to achieve and maximize their potential as they transition to adulthood and the world of work. The curriculum focuses on academic enrichment, personal and social skills, independence, employment, and health and wellness.

Josh discovered the power of micro-credentials when obtaining full-time employment in the hospitality industry. By enrolling in a series of short, focused courses on hospitality, safety skills, and food safety, he quickly built a robust skill set that set him apart from other applicants. The EAGLES Program provided Josh with support in earning his micro-credentials by offering structured guidance and resources tailored to his career goals. EAGLES also offered mentorship opportunities, connecting Josh with industry professionals who provided insights and practical advice. Workshops and networking events allowed Josh to build connections within the hospitality community at his then-current part-time job, which increased his confidence and knowledge.

The EAGLES Program partnered with Southeastern Onsite Safety to provide comprehensive OSHA training as part of their micro-credential offerings. This collaboration aimed to equip participants with essential workplace safety skills, which are crucial in the restaurant industry. Southeastern Onsite Safety brought their expertise in safety standards and regulations, delivering hands-on training sessions that covered topics like hazard recognition, proper handling of equipment, and emergency preparedness. By integrating this training into the EAGLES Program, participants like Josh not only gained valuable certifications but also enhanced their employability.

Each micro-credential Josh earned not only boosted his confidence but made him more aware of his surroundings in the workplace. Josh now thrives in a fast-paced environment and continues to learn and grow every day. Josh said, "OSHA training helped me to be aware of spills or if someone falls or gets hurt. ServSafe helped me be aware of food hazards and safety to protect my job!"

4-year university

Hospitality

Alabama

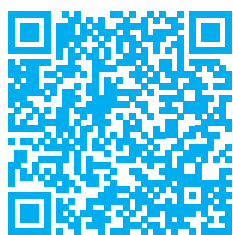


Josh earned OSHA micro-credentials through a partnership between the EAGLES Program and Southeastern Onsite Safety.



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THINK COLLEGE STORIES

CREDENTIAL PATHWAYS Makena's Story: Successful Employment with Support & Dedication

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4-year university

Animal Science & Education

Colorado

Makena wanted to go to college because she loves to learn, and she was fortunate to have the support of her parents. She shared, "My parents were very helpful, and they always believed in me. They supported me to follow my dreams." With the support of her family and the staff at University of Colorado, Colorado Springs (UCCS), Makena earned a Comprehensive Higher Education Certificate with a focus on Animal Science & Education.

The Office of Inclusive Services (OIS) at UCCS offers a 4-year, inclusive program for transition-age adults with intellectual disability. The program is accredited by the Inclusive Higher Education Accreditation Council (IHEAC). Students earn a Comprehensive Higher Education Certificate with a specific area of focus. To earn this certificate, students must complete 75 credits/clock hours, maintain a cumulative GPA of 2.0 or higher, take at least half of their courses in their area of focus, successfully complete four semesters of work experience, and participate regularly in campus activities with other UCCS students. Peer mentors support students to participate in class with their fellow classmates, complete homework and submit assignments, learn to use Canvas and other technology, follow their schedule, and take advantage of all that the UCCS campus has to offer.

At UCCS, Makena took courses in biology, nutrition, and animal sciences to learn all about animals. Makena also took courses such as Public Speaking that helped build communication and teamwork skills. She said, "I got support from the staff. They made modifications, and my mentors helped me with my course assignments. I also learned a lot about being on time and using my calendar. My mentors and staff and I all worked together, and I was able to get my credential." Makena earned her certificate in 2024.

Makena was also supported by staff at OIS to get her driver's license. She says she is practicing a lot and hopes to someday have the confidence to drive more. Makena's job at the UCCS Campus Farm taught her a great work ethic and some of the basics of having a job, like how to clock in and out, turn in your timecard, and communicate with your boss.

About her overall college experience, Makena said, "I got such a great life by going to college. It is a lot of hard work, and it is also the best ever!" She learned to be confident and to work hard. She is working part time at the zoo and has enrolled at Pike's Peak State College to earn a certificate in Zoo Keeping Technology.

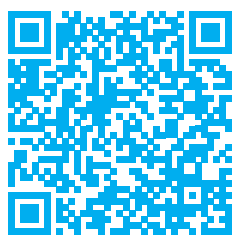


"I got such a great life by going to college." Makena learned to be confident and to work hard by going to college.



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CREDENTIAL PATHWAYS

Mclver's Story: Staying Power and Stability

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4-year university

Customer relations

South Carolina

After finishing college, Mclver and his family weren't sure what was next for him. They attended an open house for ClemsonLIFE at Clemson University where they learned that college offered a mix of employment, independent living, and traditional coursework. This experience confirmed their decision that college was the best option for Mclver, and he hasn't looked back.

The ClemsonLIFE program at Clemson University offers a collegiate experience that prepares young people with intellectual disability for competitive employment and independent living through a combination of academic coursework and career exploration. The program is designed for students who desire a postsecondary experience on a college campus. ClemsonLIFE incorporates functional academics, independent living, employment, and social skills in a public university setting with the goal of producing self-sufficient young adults.

Mclver graduated from ClemsonLIFE in 2014 with a certificate of postsecondary education after completing three years of programming. Mclver completed the 2-year Basic Program while living on campus, followed by a year of in the Advanced Program where he lived off campus in his own apartment. During his years in the program, Mclver took around 14-15 credit hours focusing on traditional university coursework, functional academics, and employment. Mclver also participated in a variety of employment internships, working in maintenance, food service, and groundskeeping. Mclver shared that while he learned many job-specific skills during his employment placements, he felt that the experiences helped him most with customer service and leadership skills, which he still uses to this day.

Mclver has been in his current position as a warehouse manager for an event rental company for over eight years. He is a full-time employee and receives full benefits. He has continued to build upon his leadership skills with his current work team by being a good team member and getting along with his coworkers. His strong work ethic and job performance earned him a promotion, and he is responsible for inventorying all equipment as it is checked in and out of the facility. He also lives independently in his own apartment and has a girlfriend who he loves spending time with. When asked if college was worth it, he quickly states that it was difficult, but he learned a lot of important life skills that have enabled him to reach his full potential.

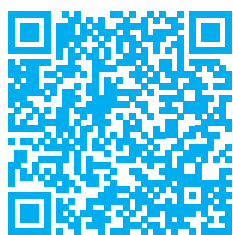


Mclver shared that he learned many job-specific skills during his employment placements, but the customer service and leadership skills are ones he still uses to this day.



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Nathan's Story: Carpe Diem

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4-year university

Mechanical Engineering

California

Nathan's determination and drive were evident from an early age. In high school, he excelled both academically and athletically. He was a member of his varsity track team, and played as an offensive and defensive lineman for the football team. To continue his education, Nathan enrolled in the Transition to Independent Living (TIL) Program at Taft College.

The TIL Program is an inclusive postsecondary educational experience for students with intellectual and/or developmental disabilities that also offers on and off-campus housing. TIL program staff work with each student to establish short-and long-term goals and write Individual Program Plans to assist students in attaining these goals. Students participate in the program for an average of 22 months and are eligible for graduation when they complete the required course work and independently demonstrate the learned skills. Students are awarded a Certificate in Transition to Independent Living when they complete the program, and many also earn other credentials from the college.

Since fall 2021, Nathan has worked 24 hours a week as an After School Assistant for the STEM & CTE Department at Taft College. He has gained recognition as the college's "3D printing expert," designing and printing the new Taft College Bookstore Carpe Diem seal, along with numerous other projects for the campus.

Nathan embodies independence and resourcefulness. He lives in his own apartment in Taft, drives his own car, and enjoys hobbies like golfing, RC cars, RC airplanes, and video games. He even built his own computer, showcasing his technical skills and curiosity.

A key part of Nathan's personal journey has been his relationship with Mary, whom he met during a TIL program gathering. Nathan and Mary connected instantly and have been excitedly planning their future together.

In 2022, Nathan graduated from the Taft College TIL Program, a pivotal moment in his life. Nathan earned the Certificate in Transition to Independent Living and completed a certification in CPR/First Aid. During his time at TIL, he began pursuing his passion for mechanical engineering and is now on track to transfer to either Cal State Bakersfield or Cal State Chico. Nathan's ultimate goal is to earn his bachelor's degree in mechanical engineering and work in Aerospace Defense Contracting. He finds joy in the hands-on and theoretical computational aspects of engineering, and his future in the field looks bright.



**Nathan's ultimate goal is to
work in Aerospace
Defense Contracting.**



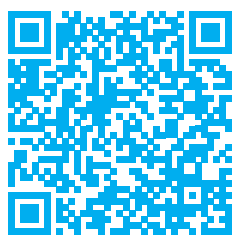
ThinkCollege

INCLUSIVE HIGHER EDUCATION NETWORK

INSTITUTE FOR COMMUNITY INCLUSION, UMASS BOSTON

Why are postsecondary education credentials important?

Earning a postsecondary education credential creates a better starting point for students with intellectual disability entering the job market and adult life. Those who access higher education are more likely to be employed, earn higher wages, and have stronger social and professional networks. There are more than 350 colleges and universities in the US with various credential options providing college students with intellectual disability opportunities for better employment outcomes and more successful adult lives.



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THINK COLLEGE STORIES

CREDENTIAL PATHWAYS

Patrick's Story: Driven to Achieve Automotive Services Skills

This series of stories aims to shed light on the transformative power of higher education credentials for students with intellectual disability. Through real-life examples, we explore how earning credentials in various fields has not only equipped these individuals with essential skills but has also paved the way for meaningful employment opportunities.

Career Technical Education

Automotive Service Technician

Florida

Patrick wanted to have a career that supports his wife and family. He knew he enjoyed working on cars and took automotive classes in high school. After high school, he enrolled in the Automotive Service Technician program at Ft. Myers Technical College (FMTC) in 2021 with support through the How I Reach Employment (HIRE) program.

The HIRE Program at FMTC is a postsecondary non-degree seeking transition program designed for students with intellectual disability. Through the HIRE program, Patrick was able to access in-class support, tutoring, and other accommodations in the Automotive Service Technician program, which prepares each student to enter the automotive field as an entry-level technician. The 1,800-hour program includes coursework to prepare students to earn several industry certifications through the National Institute for Automotive Service Excellence (ASE) and an externship. The HIRE program closely monitored his academic performance and stepped in with extra supports when needed.

To say that Patrick excelled in the program would be an understatement. By the time the next cohort arrived on campus in the fall of 2022, Patrick was doing so well that the instructors tasked him with helping the new students. Patrick also showed a penchant for all things wheel related. He got so good on wheels that the instructors had him work with students who were struggling to get the concepts. As he got closer to completing his 1,800-clock-hour program in 2023, Patrick had amassed an impressive list of industry certifications: ASE Auto Maintenance and Light Repair; ASE Engine Repair; ASE Suspension and Steering; ASE Brakes; Florida Automobile Dealers Association; and ASE Heating and Air Conditioning.

Having multiple ASE certifications allowed Patrick to show prospective employers the wide range of skills he acquired in the Automotive Service Technician program. Patrick met his future employer at his technical college's career fair: The School District of Lee County. After sharing his resume, Patrick had a brief interview on the spot and followed up with an in-person interview a few weeks later, which led to a job offer. Patrick now works full-time for the district as a Service Technician, earning above average wages and receiving a comprehensive benefits package. When asked how his time at FMTC helped him get to where he is today, Patrick replied, "I never thought I would be doing what I do. Without my instructors, I couldn't have done this. I always wanted to work on cars but now I get to work on buses!"

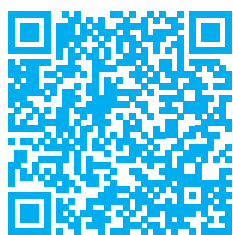


"I never thought I would be doing what I do. Without my instructors, I couldn't have done this. I always wanted to work on cars but now I get to work on buses!"



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THINK COLLEGE STORIES

CREDENTIAL PATHWAYS

Quintin's Story: Baking his Way to the Top

This series of stories aims to shed light on the transformative power of higher education credentials for students with intellectual disability. Through real-life examples, we explore how earning credentials in various fields has not only equipped these individuals with essential skills but has also paved the way for meaningful employment opportunities.

Quintin grew up in Jacksonville, Arkansas, where he sometimes struggled in school. Once in high school, Quintin started thinking more about education and his future. He decided to apply to several college programs, and on the day he graduated from high school, he received his letter of acceptance from the 3D Program at the University of Arkansas–Pulaski Technical College.

The University of Arkansas–Pulaski Technical College's 3D Program (UA-PTC 3D) offers young adults with intellectual and/or developmental disabilities postsecondary education and preparation for employment through its certificate programs in the areas of culinary arts, hospitality, and baking. Students take courses in their chosen area and earn a Certificate of Completion upon exit. They also have the opportunity to earn industry-recognized credentials, such as Certified Fundamental Cook, Certified Fundamental Pastry Culinarian, and ServSafe® Food Handler.

In addition to coursework, Quintin had a variety of different work experiences during his time in the program: a student-led lunch service, an internship in the purchasing department, and a position in a student-run bakeshop. During his last year, Quintin began a practicum placement at Great American Wings, but eventually landed a job at Blue Cake Company, a family-owned bakery in Little Rock, Arkansas. This was a result of the exceptional skills that he learned at UA-PTC 3D.

Quintin completed his program in 2022 with a Certificate of Completion in 3D Culinary from the University of Arkansas–Pulaski Technical college, Servsafe® Food Handler Certification, and the designation of CFC® from the American Culinary Federation. These certifications strengthened his resume and made him a more competitive candidate when applying for baking positions. Combined, they demonstrate his commitment to food safety, understanding of culinary principles, and readiness to work in a culinary or bakery environment. Many employers in the foodservice industry, including bakeries, require their staff to hold the Servsafe® Food Handler certification to ensure compliance with health and safety regulations. The Certified Fundamental Cook (CFC®) is a stackable credential that will follow him throughout his career. As he gains more experience, he becomes eligible for higher levels of certification that will enable him to further his career through promotions and raises.

Quintin is proud of how well he is doing. In the almost three years that he's worked at Blue Cake Company, he has been promoted to Main Baker, received a raise, and has trained many other workers to be bakers. He earned his driver's license, acquired his own apartment, and bought a car. Quintin is using the skills he learned in college to build his credit and save money.

Career Technical Education

Culinary Arts

Arkansas

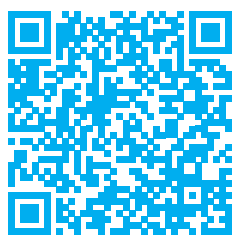


The certifications Quintin has earned demonstrate his commitment to food safety, understanding of culinary principles, and readiness to work in a culinary or bakery environment.



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THINK COLLEGE STORIES

CREDENTIAL PATHWAYS

Spencer's Story: Transferrable Skills in the Technology Industry

This series of stories aims to shed light on the transformative power of higher education credentials for students with intellectual disability. Through real-life examples, we explore how earning credentials in various fields has not only equipped these individuals with essential skills but has also paved the way for meaningful employment opportunities.

4-year university

Technology/computing

Virginia

Spencer came to Virginia Commonwealth University's (VCU) ACE-IT in College program interested in coding and programming, with the goal of working in the technology industry. He knew that many career opportunities in the technology industry require some type of credential, certification, or degree.

VCU's ACE-IT in College is an inclusive certificate program for transition-age adults with intellectual disability. The program is accredited by the Inclusive Higher Education Accreditation Council (IHEAC). Students earn a Certificate of Completion from the VCU School of Education after fulfilling the requirements of their Academic and Career Plan. The Academic and Career Plan includes 20+ VCU course credits, campus employment, and an internship. Students audit 2-3 VCU classes per semester with individualized support provided for participation in employment, college classes, and campus activities.

In addition to earning his Certificate of Completion from the VCU School of Education, Spencer was able to complete the Office of Continuing and Professional Education (OCPE) Digital Badging credential program with an individualized academic plan. To earn this credential, Spencer was required to take four courses related to computer programming, software engineering and web development, data science, and cybersecurity skills for credit. Traditionally, ACE-IT students audit courses, but to be considered for admission into the credential program, Spencer had to take each class for a grade. He had to score a C or higher in all of the courses, and Spencer finished all the courses with a B or higher.

ACE-IT staff developed strategic partnerships with employers on campus and in the community that resulted in positions that allowed Spencer to practice the skills he learned in class. Spencer had paid student employment at the VCU Labs and Classroom Computing department as a Support Technician and as a Junior Network Analyst at the VCU Network Services Office. During his final semester at VCU, Spencer completed an internship with the Federal Reserve Bank of Richmond.

The credential and certificate opened employment opportunities for Spencer after graduating from VCU. Since graduation, Spencer continued his internship at the Federal Reserve Bank for the summer and has put his cybersecurity and data management skills to work at Dominion Energy, a national energy supplier based in Richmond, VA.

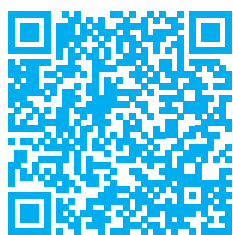


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Erik's Story: From Student to Teacher

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4-year university

Early childhood education

Tennessee

Erik always wanted to teach and work with preschool-age children. While enrolled in Next Steps at Vanderbilt University, he pursued a US Department of Labor Registered Apprenticeship in Early Childhood Education, completing it in 2025.

Next Steps at Vanderbilt University is a 4-year inclusive higher education program committed to providing neurodiverse students an inclusive, transformational postsecondary education in academics, social and career development, and independent living, while honoring equality, compassion, and excellence in all endeavors. During his final two years in the Next Steps program, Erik logged 180 hours of training (including three Vanderbilt courses and one Experiential Seminar). He paired that coursework with, 10–12 hours weekly of on-the-job learning during his junior year, and 15–20 hours during his senior year. He transitioned from a pre-Registered Apprenticeship to Registered Apprenticeship status in his final year, meeting state-recognized competencies defined by the Department of Labor.

Because Next Steps already had established partnerships with local preschools, Erik was placed in multiple classrooms throughout his studies, gaining experience with children of different ages. His coursework and internships allowed him to hone skills in lesson planning, selecting appropriate read-aloud books, and classroom management. His mentors and instructors gave regular feedback, helping him improve along the way.

The credential Erik completed through his studies is recognized by the State of Tennessee, making him more competitive in the job market. Today, he works at Vanderbilt University's Child and Family Center, serving as an Assistant Teacher at the Acorn School. He relies on many of the skills he acquired in the credential program every day: how to respond when children are upset, how to maintain control when the classroom gets noisy, how to administer first aid, and how to stay attuned to students while juggling multiple tasks. He also picked up non-instructional but crucial life skills—navigating mass transit, using ride-sharing services, and managing stress.

His journey was supported by multiple layers. Each semester, a mentor teacher checked in on Erik's progress at work, peer mentors (Ambassa'Dores) helped with his homework, and his parents helped him choose classes aligned with his interests. Next Steps also planned his semesters strategically, balancing music courses with the education classes needed for the apprenticeship.



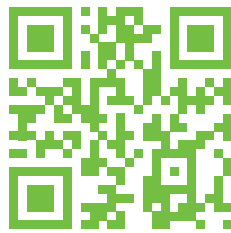
"I love my job. It makes me happy to go to work every day—and it lets me pay for my utilities, rent for my apartment, and all my groceries. I'm so grateful I went through Next Steps so I could get this great job and support myself."

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